

Francis IT - Tech Doc

FIT_Mac_Password_Recovery_Manual.pdf | January 2026 | Jami@FrancisIT.com |
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Technical Manual: macOS Password & Keychain Recovery

Phase 1: Resetting the Login Password (Apple Silicon)

Because Apple Silicon Macs (M1, M2, M3, M4) use a secure architecture, macOS Recovery is required to access the password reset tool.

1. Shut Down: Power off the Mac completely.
2. Enter Recovery: Press and hold the Power/Touch ID button until "Loading startup options" appears.
3. Select Options: Select the Options icon and click Continue.
4. Open Terminal: If prompted for a login, click "Forgot all passwords?" or use the top menu. Then go to Utilities > Terminal in the top menu bar.
5. Run Command: In Terminal, type `resetpassword` and press Enter.
6. Execute Reset: Follow the on-screen prompts to deactivate the Mac, provide Apple ID credentials if requested, and set a new password.
7. Restart: Navigate to the Apple Menu and select Restart.

Phase 2: Managing the Keychain

Post-reset, macOS will notify you that the "login" keychain cannot be unlocked as it remains encrypted with the old password.

Option A: Resetting if Old Password is Unknown

- Click Create New Keychain when the login pop-up appears.
- This establishes a new, empty keychain synchronized with your current login password.

Option B: Manual Reset via Keychain Access

- Launch Keychain Access using Spotlight (Cmd + Space).
- Select Keychain Access > Settings from the top menu.
- Select Reset Default Keychains.
- Authenticate with the new password and Restart the system.

Phase 3: iCloud Password Sync

- Go to System Settings and select your Apple ID.
- Under iCloud, verify that Passwords & Keychain is toggled ON.
- This ensures saved passwords from other devices sync back to the local machine.

Phase 4: Password Export

- Open the Passwords app and authenticate.
- Navigate to File > Export All Passwords... to create a backup.

SECURITY WARNING

The resulting export is unencrypted. It must be stored on an encrypted drive or in a physical safe.

Technical Notes

- Intel Recovery: Use Cmd + R during startup for Intel-based Macs. The Terminal command remains identical.
- Activation Lock: Password resets do not bypass Activation Lock; owner credentials are mandatory.
- FileVault: A recovery key may be requested before terminal access is granted if encryption is active.